

“Behold the church of St. Cuthbert spattered with the blood of the priests of God.”

ALCUIN OF YORK, 793

AFTER

The Viking Age came to an end during the 11th century. The kingdoms of Norway, Sweden, and Denmark evolved into more centralized states, as was happening elsewhere in Europe.

END OF THE VIKING AGE

Launching a lightning raid on a centralized state did not have the same effect as it did in the 9th and 10th centuries because, by 1500, these states had developed **organized armies and navies**. This meant that communities were able to defend themselves against attacks of the kind that the Vikings carried out.

ATLANTIC SLAVE TRADE

Raids later became central to the establishment of the Atlantic slave trade **280–81** in the 16th, 17th, and 18th centuries, where communities in western Africa bore the brunt of such attacks.

CARIBBEAN RAIDERS

Raid tactics similar to those of the Vikings were used during the same period in the Caribbean, where European navies, privateers, and pirates **sacked trading posts and preyed on shipping routes**.

THE HANSEATIC LEAGUE

Trading in the later medieval period (1100–1500) could be dangerous. In the 12th century, merchants from cities in northern Germany and the Baltic formed an alliance called the **Hanseatic League 276–77**. They traded between the Baltic, the Netherlands, and England, and carried goods from Arabia and beyond across the Russian steppes. Kiev and Novgorod, founded by Vikings, became gateways to the East. At its height, **merchants from over 60 cities** had joined, but by the end of the 15th century the league was in decline.

Crystal necklace

This crystal necklace of Viking origin with Eastern elements demonstrates how Scandinavian craftsmen adopted the styles and techniques of the various cultures they came in contact with.

Iron trading weights

These brass-covered weights were found in Hemmingby, Sweden. Each has been stamped with a different number of circles corresponding to its weight.

Viking brooch

Brooches are frequently found in Viking graves, and were used to fasten cloaks.

a square sail was attached to this mast



Viking longship at sail

A viking longship was usually 70 ft (21 m) long and 16 ft (5 m) wide. The prow was carved with interlaced decorations, and a square sail was rigged to the mast.

15 oar ports were located on each side of the longship

Gold bridle

Viking metalwork was complex and often consisted of intertwining animal shapes.

Viking longship

This ship was excavated from a royal burial site at Oseberg, Norway, and probably dates from 815–820 CE. While it is very similar to the type of ship used for everyday travel, it was almost certainly ceremonial in nature, as it is heavy and highly decorated.

longship was built of fine oak

by Charles the Simple

c. 911 CE. Rollo's great-great-grandson became William the Conqueror (see pp.192–93). Between 1016 and 1035, the Dane Cnut the Great ruled Denmark and England.

The Vikings also became great traders, sailing from Iceland to Russia and the Islamic empire. As early as 841 CE a permanent Viking settlement was founded at Dublin and the ancient

English city of York.

Vikings are even credited with being the founders of the Grand Duchy of Kiev, the forerunner of the kingdom of Muscovy and, later, Russia.